

is this magnificent fact possible, you ask? Well, because most people under the age of 21 are trying to learn something, and because most people are terrible at learning things. This isn't some cynical reflection of the modern world - it's true, and well-documented, as even a little research will reveal.

The fact is that education is currently an industry, and degrees and diplomas are the output. It's impossible to customize something that you're simultaneously trying to mass produce. So one finds broad, generic, meaningless labels - the kid is good 'at mathy stuff', so he should become an engineer. She 'likes drawing' so she'll make a great architect. All of the detail gets swept under a rug, and most households don't even realise that it's happening. Teachers in schools and universities are handling tens of students, hundreds sometimes. A student who falls behind isn't necessarily bad at the subject, or incapable of it. But for some reason, we live in a binary age of two educational extremes - spoonfeeding to an extent that students' brains begin to atrophy, or mad pressure to 'excel' such that the proverbial rat race becomes the only reality.

For kids, tutors can provide that extra help, that little extra attention, a new and personalised spin on a hard-to-grasp concept. Tutors can guide a child (assuming they're not tutoring only due to an incompetence at everything else), mentor her, and actually even shape her interests and eventual career. It's for this demographic that tutoring, while perhaps not as financially rewarding, offers the unique opportunity to not only make a positive difference in a child's future, but to spark in her an interest in subjects otherwise found boring.

For older students in college or even beyond, tutors can provide a convenient way to brush up an old concept, to absorb a new one, or even, to learn a useful new skill that can help someone's career. This is admittedly a smaller, more tightly wound market, but there are ways to break into it.

What topics are most in demand?

The sad fact of life is that the stereotypically 'boring' subjects usually pay better, attracting more students towards them, and hence, greatly skewing the tutoring market. The largest demand for tutoring will be in the subjects of mathematics and science at the school level, and then computer science engineering, medicine and accounts for higher levels. There's also a lot of demand for entrance-exam tutoring - right from the (abbreviation overdose incoming) +2 level CLAT/IIT JEE/AIPMT/SAT to the graduate level GRE/CAT/GMAT/GATE.